KEY TERM

Title sequence a series of shots and music or graphics that appear at the start of a programme

The answer, of course, is that they are all important at different times and in different ways. Ultimately, it is the performance in front of the camera which attracts and keeps audiences, but for those performances to be outstanding, the team behind the camera need to have done their specialist jobs first.

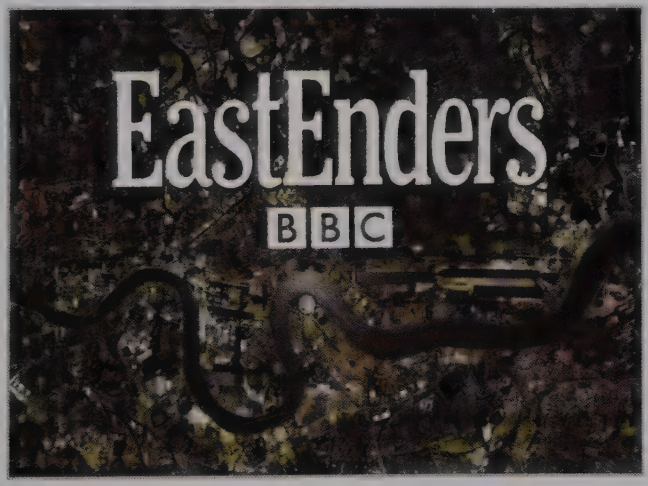
A television production is a complex task, and planning is absolutely vital. However, some things are unpredictable, no matter how good the plan.

- Multiple takes are often needed to 'get it right' in front of the camera – look at programmes which are about moments when actors do not get it right.
- Live audiences: unpredictability on the part of guests and audiences and having to manage large numbers.
- The weather: some programmes have to be cancelled due to poor weather conditions, while others have to be suspended until weather conditions are right – it is not always possible to create a sunny day.
- Illness or scandal: a key character or presenter may be too ill to appear or involved in some public scandal.
- Special effects and stunts do not always go to plan.

Skill and teamwork are needed to get over these problems as they arise. Summer scenes for the *X-Files* were filmed in snowy Vancouver by blowing the snow off the grass first.

Title sequences

The language of the moving image text is a complex mixture of codes and messages that audiences are expert at reading and understanding. A great way to find out about the ways moving image texts communicate with audiences is by examining **title sequences**, which are highly crafted short texts.





Images from the title sequence *of EastEnders*

Look at the shots in **3** from the title sequence of *EastEnders*. What clues do they give you about the programme? You can see some ideas in the table on the next page – can you add any to the list?

What you can see	What you can work out about the programme
The River Thames	It is set in London.
The Millennium Dome at Greenwich	It is set in the present, probably near Limehouse Reach.
The title is in big, bold writing.	It is called EastEnders.
The second image is in more close-up than the first.	The programme will focus on a small part of London.

If you are able to watch the opening, you will be able to pick out many more points. For example:

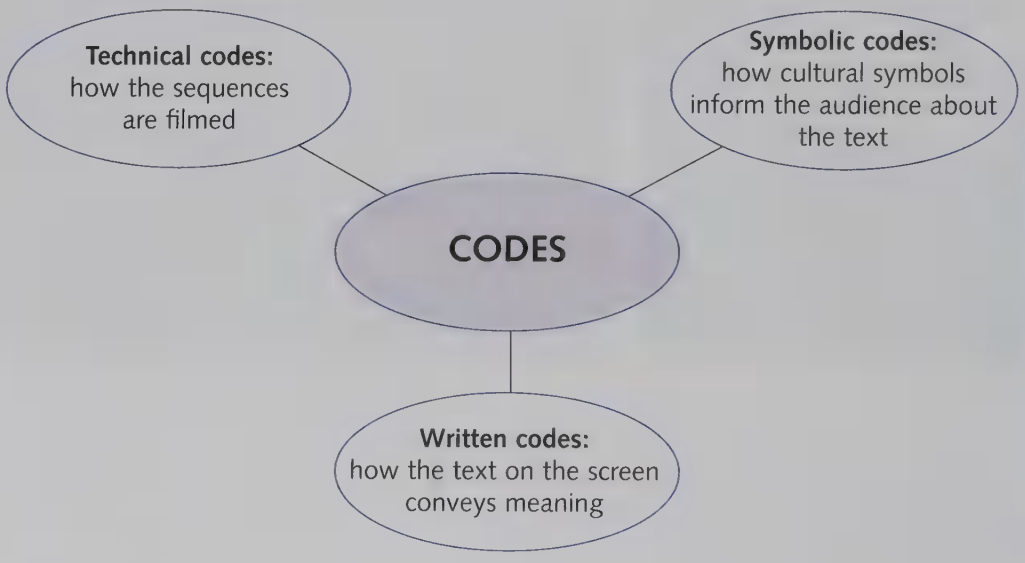
- The camera looks down on the map and rotates just before the title comes up, giving the viewer a different view of the river and its surroundings.
- The title emerges from the map just as the private lives of the characters emerge from their East End homes in the storylines for the programme.

ACTIVITY 2

Watch the title sequence of *Coronation Street*. Pick out the features that give you clues about the programme and put them in a table like the one for *EastEnders*.

Did the *EastEnders* title sequence tell you anything about the characters in the series? You may be surprised that no characters appear, but producers of title sequences often avoid showing people because then the sequence has to be changed much more often as characters join and leave the cast. The title sequence of *Neighbours*, for example, includes characters and has to be changed regularly. Look back at **3**: why do you think that the *EastEnders* sequence had to be changed in about 2000?

One way to approach the analysis of texts such as title sequences is to break down the task into three distinct areas, each of which focuses on a different type of code (see the diagram in **4**).



Types of codes

TIP

Spider diagrams are a quick and clear way to show the examiner what you know.

KEY TERMS

Dissolve when one screen image fades into another

Fade when the screen image gradually disappears

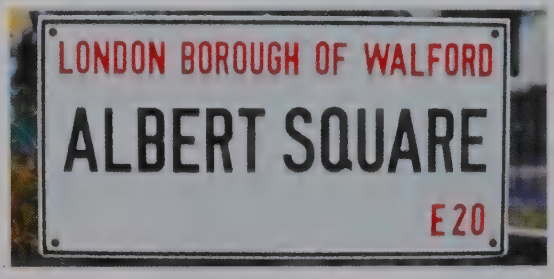
Transition moving from one screen image to another

Wipe when one screen image appears to wipe away another

Technical codes

Technical codes include any of the technical processes used to create the text. Features to look for include:

- *Types of shot*, e.g. establishing shots. These may be of famous landmarks, such as the Millennium Dome, that indicate where events take place, or of signs to show where they are (see **5**) or what their function is, e.g. a sign saying Grange Hill School.



5 This establishing shot shows the location of *EastEnders*

- The **transitions** between shots, such as **fades**, **wipes**, **dissolves** and others.
- The *angle of the shot:* low angles make the subject seem larger and more imposing; high angles have the reverse effect.
- *Camera movements* such as *zooming in* on a subject or *tracking shots*, where the camera follows alongside the subject. This type of shot gets its name from the tracks that are put down so that the camera moves smoothly (**6**).



6 A camera recording a tracking shot

Symbolic codes

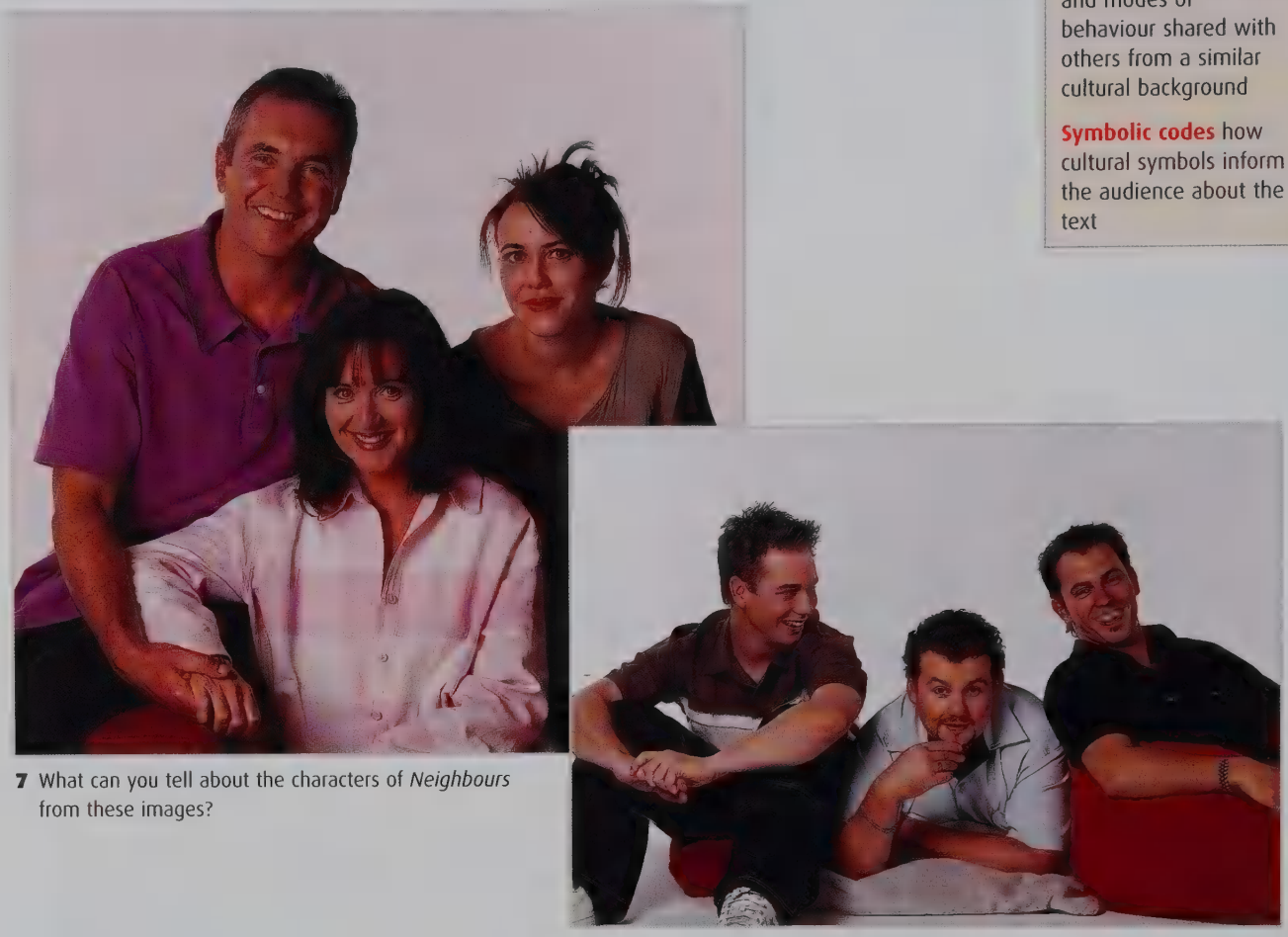
Objects, settings, body language, clothing, colour and soundtrack – the **mise-en-scene** of the sequence – use **symbolic codes** to inform the viewer. As you examine the text, you read the meaning of what you see and hear. People's cultural backgrounds will be important in the way they read an image. Facial expressions and body language are read according to the ways people's backgrounds have led them to interpret them. A polite hand gesture in some cultures may give offence in others. It all depends on a person's **situated culture**.

KEY TERMS

Mise-en-scene settings, costumes, body language, etc. used within the scene to convey the message to the audience

Situated culture the everyday surroundings and modes of behaviour shared with others from a similar cultural background

Symbolic codes how cultural symbols inform the audience about the text



7 What can you tell about the characters of *Neighbours* from these images?

ACTIVITY 3

Watch the title sequence of *Neighbours*.

1 Answer these questions using only what you can see.
   - Where do the characters live?
   - What is each of the characters telling us from their expressions and gestures?

2 Imagine you have been asked to introduce a new character into the programme, such as an elderly aunt who nags everyone. In groups, try different poses and facial expressions to suggest the sort of character you want. Act these out for the rest of the group as a 'freeze-frames' or tableaus where you adopt the pose and stay perfectly still to show what the still picture will look like. Discuss which was the most effective and appropriate for the programme.

If you watch the title sequence you will also hear the **signature tune.** This soon becomes recognisable to the audience and is seen as belonging to it like its 'signature'. Signature tunes signal themes in different ways.

- Some signature tunes communicate meaning through the style, mood and tone.
- Sometimes a particular instrument will be used to signal the setting. In *Coronation Street* the trumpet suggests brass band music associated with working-class northern England – the setting for the programme.
- Some signature tunes have song lyrics which prepare the audience for the programme by introducing themes that will be explored.

ACTIVITY 4

1 Think about the signature tune for *Neighbours*. What do the lyrics tell you about the story?

2 Choose one other signature tune with lyrics. How do the music and the words signal the themes of the programme?

Written codes

The writing on the screen may seem less important than the pictures and the music, but the font style and size, together with the position and movement of the text, can contribute to the ways the audience read the meaning. Look at the style of font used for the hit show *Buffy the Vampire Slayer* in **8**.



This lettering helps to convey meaning

Suggest two reasons why the title has been designed in this way. How does it signal the **genre** of the programme? Why has this particular font been chosen?

Does the font style make a difference to the way the text is read?

KEY TERMS

Genre a type or category of media text, such as a documentary, with certain predictable characteristics

Signature tune the soundtrack played over the images in the title sequence of the programme

ACTIVITY 5

Choose the best font from the box below for a title for each of these genres:

- Horror
- Romantic comedy
- Science fiction
- Game show
- Crime fiction

In each case the show is called *Last Chance*.

ALGERIAN	Fashion	MATISSE
Bauhaus	**Goudy heavyface**	**Matura Script Capitals**
Blackadder	Jokerman	Old English Text
Broadway	*Lucida Handwriting*	**Playbill**
Chiller	Rendo	**Serpentine**

If you prefer, find suitable fonts on a computer or design your own.

Case study: the title sequences to *Star Trek*



Star Trek was hugely popular in the 1960s

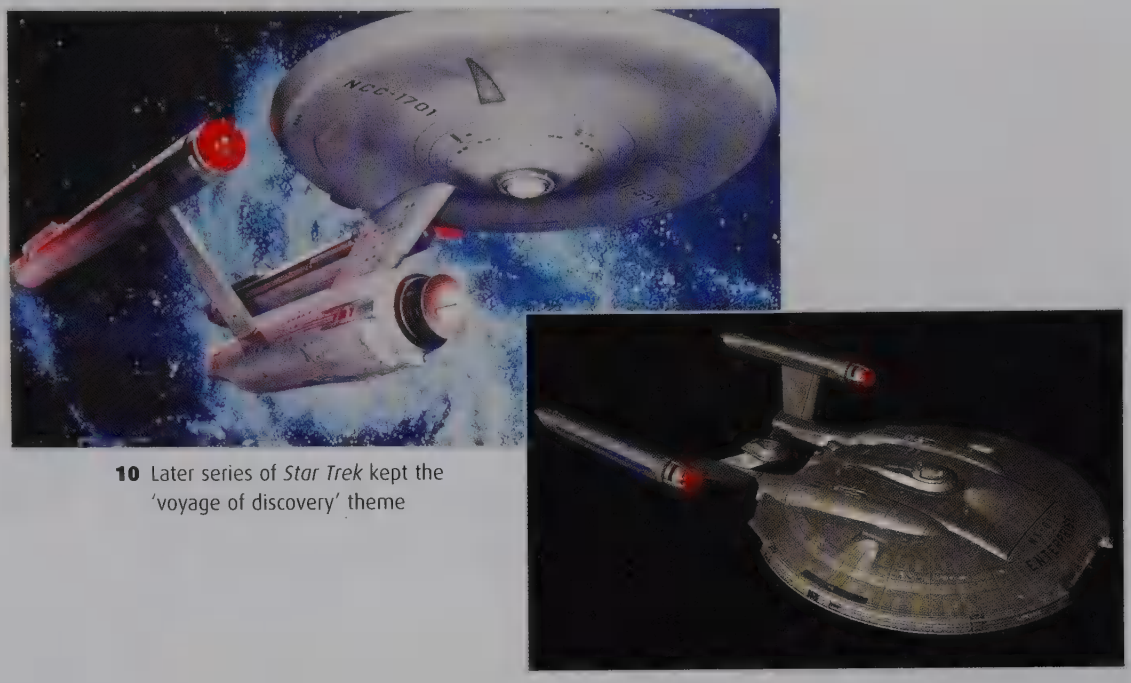
Sometimes the title sequence of a programme can become famous in its own right. In the 1960s the USA and Soviet Union were competing to put a man on the moon. *Star Trek* was first made in 1964 to exploit the interest in space travel this caused.

A voice-over was used in the title sequence to give the audience background information about the story. It explained that the crew of the star ship *Enterprise* were on a five-year mission to explore space – to 'seek out new life and new civilisations …' and 'boldly go where no man has gone before'. This phrase has become almost as famous as the series itself. Meanwhile the visual sequence showed the starship leaving the solar system and moving out into space.

Sequels used a similar title sequence, but changed 'no man' to 'no one'– what reason can you suggest for the change?

TIP

Writing about the hstorical events that influence the programme-makers shows the examiner that you understand its context.



10 Later series of *Star Trek* kept the 'voyage of discovery' theme

KEY TERMS

Prequel programme or series set in a time period before the first series, e.g. *Superman – the Early Years* or *Star Wars: Episode 1 The Phantom Menace*

Sequel continuation of a story, usually with the same characters or settings and themes

Star Trek – the prequel

There have been many more *Star Trek* sequels, but when the title sequence to the **prequel** *Enterprise* (2001) was being designed new ideas were needed to give the show a different feel.

Enterprise is set 150 years after the present and 105 years before the original series. The early version of the starship *Enterprise* travels mainly in the solar system and is technologically behind the original and its sequels.

The title sequence abandons the usual style and instead shows a historical summary of human achievement in travel and discovery and human aspiration to travel in space. The ships shown in the sequence are all called *Enterprise* but they are not all starships.

The fictitious starships include the first warp ship, the *Phoenix*, as seen in the feature film *Star Trek: First Contact* (1996), and finally, the 'new' *Enterprise NX-01* that features in the series. Try to watch the sequence. At what point does the title sequence change from historical accuracy to fictitious events based on the *Star Trek* stories?

TIP

You can find the lyrics of *Faith of the Heart* by following the links on Heinemann Hotlinks.

As well as changes to the overall visual style of the title sequence, *Enterprise* has a very different signature tune. Instead of the instrumental cue of the other series it has a contemporary soft-rock song called *Faith of the Heart*, performed by English opera tenor Russell Watson. The melody and the lyrics work alongside the pictures to suggest the past, present and future as well as the mission of Enterprise (both the series and the ship).

Media texts offer the audience a view of the world and sometimes invite them to make a judgement about events. How does the title sequence of *Enterprise* represent mankind's experience in terms of travel and discovery?

ACTIVITY 10

Look at the title sequences of the original *Star Trek* series, its sequels and prequels. How is human progress represented?

ACTIVITY 11 EXTENSION

1 Watch a variety of title sequences. Comment on how meaning is conveyed through visual images and soundtrack. Consider:
   - how location and time are established
   - how groups of people are represented, if at all
   - how the soundtrack gives clues about the content of the programme
   - how any lettering used relates to the rest of the sequence.

2 **Storyboard** a title sequence of your own to launch a new programme (see pages 172–173 in Unit 9 if you need help). Think about all the features you looked out for in the sequences you watched.

TIP

Put your storyboard from Activity 11 into a folder. This could be included in your final coursework folder as planning or pre-production work.

Television genres



In media terms, a genre is any type of text – programme, film, popular music, etc. – that can be identified or recognised by typical conventions or characteristics (see pages 13–14).

ACTIVITY 12

1 Look in the daily TV schedule in a newspaper. List all the genres that you can find, such as situation comedy and news.

2 In small groups, think of a new TV programme aimed at teenagers. Write down what genre the programme belongs to and when it will be shown. Add any other important details, such as what will happen and who will feature in it.

3 Present your ideas to the rest of the class, and hear the ideas of other groups.

4 Think about all the ideas put forward. What were the most noticeable similarities and differences? Were there any particularly popular genres of programmes? Why might that be?

You will probably notice that some television genres are more popular than others, and that these are often scheduled during peak time. TV programmes are produced by teams of people who conduct extensive **market research** in order to find out what different audiences want to see on television. They are aware that audiences use the media to satisfy certain needs or requirements. Blumler and Katz discussed such audience demand in 1974 in their theory of Uses and Gratifications (see page 88). In summary, they suggested that audiences need to:

- be INFORMED and EDUCATED about the world
- IDENTIFY with characters and situations
- be ENTERTAINED
- use the media as a talking point for SOCIAL INTERACTION
- ESCAPE from their daily lives.

KEY TERMS

Market research finding out what audiences like or dislike about aspects of the media through interviews, surveys and focus groups

Storyboard key moments of a story shown using images and notes – see the example on page 107

Sub-genre genres can be divided up further into sub-genres, e.g. teen comedies are a sub-genre of comedy

ACTIVITY 13

Look again at the television programmes and genres you identified in the daily schedules. Apply the Uses and Gratifications theory to them in order to see what audience needs are being satisfied by each genre. Put your answers in a table like the one below by writing ticks in the correct columns.

Programme	Inform	Identify	Entertain	Social interaction	Escape
Wildlife documentary	✓		✓	✓	

Introduction to television drama

Television drama is a hugely popular television genre, attracting wide-ranging audiences simply because there are so many different dramas to choose from in terms of both style and content. Since it is such a large genre, it is useful to divide it up further into **sub-genres** such as medical drama, police drama and docu-drama, in order to look at it more closely



11 David Jason in the Yorkshire Television drama *Micawber* (2002)

ACTIVITY 14

1. Watch the opening sequences of a range of TV dramas. Finish a copy of diagram **12** showing the typical sub-genre conventions or characteristics of each one. One has been done for you already. You may need to add more arms or boxes.
2. What other impressions do you get from the opening sequences? Try to add in more notes on your diagram about any of the following areas: *music*, *striking images*, *on-screen text*.
3. Discuss with a partner what storylines are suggested by the openings. What clues tell you the kinds of stories that will be important in the programmes? Look out for where the camera spends extra time, giving importance to certain moments and particular characters and their stories.